

The rest of that evening Naomi stayed in the bedroom and Ben stayed downstairs. He began to feel guilty about his reaction to Naomi and decided to apologize. But by the time he went upstairs she was asleep.

Naomi tried to continue to work, but morning sickness forced her to miss more and more days. Finally, her supervisor called her in to confront the issue.

“Naomi, I know you’ve had a tough time with this pregnancy, but you’ve missed six days in the last two weeks. We need someone who can do the work. Why don’t you take a month’s leave of absence and stay home? I’d like to keep you, but maybe I can hire a temp for a few weeks. If you’re doing better, then come back and see me, and we’ll try to bring you back.”

“Oh, Melanie, that’s thoughtful, but I can’t afford to stay home,” Naomi replied. “We’re—I can’t really talk about it, but things are pretty tight financially. I have to work, or we can’t keep up with our bills. Sometimes I don’t see how we’ll ever get caught up.”

Melanie Moore grew thoughtful, then said, “If you’re that strapped, maybe you and Ben ought to see about filing for bankruptcy. You’re not going to be able to work while you’re so sick. And if you continue the way you’re going, you will ruin your health and the baby’s too.”

“Bankruptcy?” Naomi said. “I never envisioned us having to do anything like that.”

“My husband’s an attorney,” Melanie replied. “I can assure you, it’s no stigma to file for bankruptcy. Here’s his card. At least talk it over with Ben and give my husband, Joe, a call if you’d like to look into it.”

That evening Naomi was quiet through dinner. Ben sensed something new was on her mind, but he dreaded asking what it was. Their relationship had been so tense since Naomi told him she was pregnant that they rarely spoke to each other without getting into some kind of argument. Finally, he spoke up. “What’s wrong now, Naomi? You have barely said two words since I got home.”